good to me," said a member of ExCom whose voice on the tape remains unidentified. He seemed to express the opinion of the majority.

Earlier in the meeting Kennedy had voiced his support for Taylor's advocacy of all-out retaliation for any shooting down of a US aircraft. But immediate retaliation against a missile site was impossible—it was getting dark in Cuba. "It's too late. This is why it gets into tomorrow," explained McNamara. Neither the president nor his advisers could make sense of what had just happened. They appeared to be certain of only one thing: the shooting down of the plane was a deliberate act in the dangerous game being played by the Kremlin and its master, Nikita Khrushchev.[2]

The problem of American missiles in Turkey, addressed in the morning and afternoon sessions of ExCom, remained on the agenda and took on new urgency in light of the loss of the U-2 over Cuba. Kennedy's idea of getting rid of the missiles had only one strong supporter—Robert McNamara. But his reasoning had nothing to do with Kennedy's. If the president wanted to remove the missiles in order to prevent invasion and possible war, his secretary of defense wanted them out because by now he was leaning toward invasion, as advocated by the chiefs. There was a chance that the Soviets might respond to an invasion with a military strike somewhere else, and the missiles seemed to be a likely target—"sitting ducks" waiting to be "taken out." "I would suggest that to minimize the Soviet response against NATO following a US attack on Cuba, we get those Jupiters out of Turkey before the Cuban attack," McNamara told the ExCom. The majority was not convinced.[3]

When Kennedy left the cabinet room around 5:00 p.m. to attend his scheduled appointments, there was still no consensus on a response to Khrushchev's proposal to swap missiles. With Kennedy away, his aides continued the discussion and drafted alternative versions of a letter from the president to Khrushchev. Robert Kennedy and Sorensen were putting the finishing touches on the draft, which made no mention of the missiles in Turkey. McNamara was arguing for unilateral withdrawal of the missiles from Turkey and an exchange of the land-based Jupiters for sea-based Polaris missiles, while McCone of the CIA, backed by George Ball, was preparing a message to Khrushchev that combined an ultimatum to stop